



cornerstone of India's success in the longest format. The No. 4 spot, synonymous with the two generational talents, has produced the best average — 50.75 — amongst all other batting positions for India since Tendulkar first assumed the mantle, with No. 3 being a distant second, at 45.50. Understandably, the lack of an apparent successor seems to have amplified the lacuna left in the wake of Kohli.

Musical chairs

While Jaiswal, Rahul, and Shubman Gill are going to be staples in the top four for the years to come, the order could be informed by who is anointed at No. 4. India's five-match Test series against England at home last year saw a

saga of musical chairs for that spot in the absence of Kohli. Rahul, Shreyas Iyer, Rajat Patidar and Devdutt Padikkal were slotted in that position over the course of that series, but Shreyas and Patidar are not in the scheme of things at present, while Padikkal is recovering from injury. Rahul, a recurring casualty of batting-order rejigs, may be shunted to No. 4 just as he was finding his feet again as an opener.

But that arrangement could disturb Gill's preferred No. 3 spot as he could be asked to partner Jaiswal at the top. Sai Sudharsan, with a prolific IPL season under his belt, is primed for a debut but the management could be averse to making him open at the outset in English conditions. Moreover, the

Bidding adieu to Tests: Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma had also retired from T20Is after India won the World Cup last year, and they will only be available for ODI cricket going forward. AFP

southpaw has some experience of batting in the middle order in First-Class cricket and even scored a century for Surrey at No. 6 in the County Championship last year.

In the event of Gill opening with Jaiswal and Rahul dropping to No. 4, Sudharsan could take up the No. 3 spot, which is not too much different from opening the innings. He has two centuries at that position in First-Class cricket but has only tallied 12 runs in his last four innings at No.